

A tropical resort scene featuring a large swimming pool in the foreground, a sandy beach, and a thatched-roof hut on the right. Several palm trees are scattered throughout the landscape, and the ocean is visible in the background under a clear blue sky.

DISCOVER MORE

An Imaginative Hideaway.

Hidden among dense foliage within the Baa Atoll UNESCO Biosphere Reserve, in the Maldives

Soneva Fushi inspires the imagination. The award-winning resort truly defines the essence of barefoot luxury with Robinson Crusoe simplicity.





LIFE'S A BEACH

SONU SHIVDASANI CEO OF SONEVA GROUP TALKS ECO LUXURY WITH JOSEPH FARODOYE

How did your journey begin?

I was studying at Oxford University and English universities have big holidays, so the terms are normally x3 times 8 weeks, so most of the year you don't have to be in town. You're expected to study and research but not necessarily all of the time be grounded in one place. Eva introduced me to the Maldives and we loved it and we would stay here for a month and in those days Maldives was a simple resort, so we introduced luxury tourism here in 1995.

How important is sustainability to the Soneva Group?

It is in essence part of our DNA and our core purpose, I believe that companies must have a purpose beyond simply enriching shareholders and paying employees a salary. When you can do that, it can be very motivating for the people running the organisation and the employees.

What is the secret to maintaining your high standard?

Magical service can only be trained to a certain extent, it needs to be instilled and people need to have a passion for the company they work for.

So, our core purpose of slow life is something that our hosts are very engaged in and it can drive to even more engagement. So, in a way, if you have a purpose that rings true, it goes beyond just paying salaries to your employees. They get passionate about what they're doing, they get up every morning with great zeal, excitement and energy.

What are the most important aspects of Soneva Fushi?

The most important thing is not how big the villas are, how many restaurants you have or how many spa treatments you have, it's really the passion and energy from the team. The more authentic and genuine you are to your core purpose, the more engaged our hosts are and the better services they deliver.

Where do most of your staff come from?

75% of our employees are not just from the Maldives but a majority of them are from the islands next door like Maalhos and Eydha Fushi. And of course, we engage a lot with the local community whether it's teaching the island of Eydha Fushi how to swim because, the irony of it all is that the local population are living in an area of outstanding natural beauty.



especially under the water and on an island like Eydha Fushi a third of the people couldn't swim. So, how can you teach people to preserve the environment if they've never seen it and they had never seen the beauty under the water. So, one of the programmes we have is to teach all the school children how to swim, now on the island of Eydha Fushi, all of the school children know how to swim.

What other community initiatives are Soneva Group investing in?

We have swimming teachers who come in from abroad and we run that initiative throughout the atoll, there are various initiatives like that and we've also funded a school there - so the more engaged we are with the community the more passionate they are. Our slow life core purpose is to combine luxury, sustainability and wellness and we believe that we offer our guests luxury whilst minimising our impact on the planet and enhancing their health and well-being.

How have you successfully merged sustainability and luxury?

These concepts are traditionally considered opposites - People say if it's a luxury it can't be sustainable or if it's a luxury it can't be good for you.

The proof of our success is the fact that we've won the equivalent of the Oscars for sustainability, and the only hotel group in the world, I believe, to have won the World Travel and Tourism Council, Tourism for Tomorrow award twice and the equivalent of the Oscars for luxury and standards.

Conde Nast Traveller UK have awarded us twice, best of the best in all of their categories i.e. airlines, city hotels, European hotels, Asian hotels etc. and we've been in the top twice.

What are your plans for the Soneva brand in the future?

We have Soneva in Aqua as a resort concept, but it will be a movable concept with boats in the Maldives, some in Thailand and then some in other parts of the world but they will move around to other locations — it's really like a global resort. Initially, when the scale is small, we are placing them near the resort so that they can receive the support of the resort. Over time, as we scale up, there will be a centralised team and we can then look at locations where we don't yet operate.

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POETRY IN THE LUNAR CYCLE

The Rolex Cellini collection celebrates the eternal elegance of traditional timepieces with a contemporary touch. Consisting of classically inspired models, it combines Rolex's know-how and high standards of perfection in an approach that heightens watchmaking heritage in its most timeless form.

Rolex is introducing a new model in its Cellini collection, the Cellini Moonphase, featuring an exclusive display of the lunar cycle. The 39 mm Cellini Moonphase is offered in 18 ct Everose gold.

The Cellini Moonphase patented moonphase module is astronomically accurate for 122 years. Born of Rolex watchmaking tradition, it evokes the finest examples of contemporary monumental architecture, where grandiose proportions and clean lines are accompanied by a strikingly modern reading of space and light. Freed of the formal constraints of their heritage, fully assuming their role as refined guardians of time, symbols of luxury steeped in values that reveal an authentic art de vivre.

CELLINI MOONPHASE

39mm, 18ct Everose gold, polished finish





BUILDING HOMES PEOPLE LOVE TO LIVE IN

Modern design, international construction and a high standard



P U R P L E P R E M I U M . C O M



PURPLE PREMIUM | WOODBURY ESTATE, LAGOS



BUYING RIGHT NIGERIA

Buying a property with no advice in Nigeria has been compared to, 'Jumping out of an aeroplane with no parachute'.

Buying a property with no advice in Nigeria has been compared to, 'Jumping out of an aeroplane with no parachute'. Reoccurring problems in Real Estate surrounding product quality, customer service and security have been echoed among the Nigerian and international community for decades. The need for high quality product, affordable payment solutions and a friendly service with aftercare for those inevitable snags has been long overdue. And the need for a simple transparent property service for the diaspora and those living in other countries has reached a crucial point.

Location, location, location is one of the most important factors when considering buying an investment property anywhere and extremely important when considering the Nigerian property terrain. Which is where Purple Premium come into their own, with a selection of highly sought-after developments built to suit the needs of the diaspora.

Modern design, international construction and a high standard of finishing are synonymous with their products. Their current developments consist of 2 and 3 Bedroom flats, 4 Bedroom Terraced Houses and 5 Bedroom Semi Detached Houses aimed at middle income families built to the highest specifications. Taking particular care to landscaping, creating the kind of lifestyle product normally associated with a much higher price tag.

Their pricing is remarkably affordable with the average property costing around £35,000 - £120,000.

But what is more enticing, are the affordable payment plans available with the majority of Purple Premium products, offering mortgages that buyers can take advantage of with as little as 40% deposit a perfect example is Woodbury Estate, Lagos a current development.

With traffic and commuting at the top of the agenda, positioning on the right side of the tracks of this multifaceted region can make a huge difference to your productivity. Purple Premium have taken this into account and offer great links to shopping hubs, social outlets and locations that are close enough to main destination areas that are densely populated with commercial companies. All of these elements combined, create investment ready properties that simply cannot be ignored.

Purple Premium have securely established themselves as a go to developer for premium real estate investment services for the African diaspora and can help alleviate some of the risks faced when tackling it alone.

Purple Premium Ltd develop high quality opulent homes across Nigeria for Nigerians in the Diaspora. As a market leader, Richard Obahor, CEO of Purple Premium spearheads the U.K. & Nigerian based Real Estate Company to the highest heights of international real estate. Over Richards illustrious career he has won numerous international awards and his philosophy remains "if you would dream anyway, you might as well dream big".

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VANESSA GOUNDEN

Beauty, Brains and Power, a powerful unique mix of characteristics that epitomize one of the most successful entrepreneurs in Africa, a mother dedicated to her family, a seasoned activist who served under Nelson Mandela during his term in office and an international business mogul recognised by Forbes as one of the wealthiest self made women in Africa.

Tell us about your journey to becoming globally recognised as South Africa's most notable female pioneer, as quoted by Forbes?

It is firstly an honor to be recognized as a notable female pioneer. My journey to where I am could read like an adventure novel and I never aspired to live up to any labels. I did what I felt was right at the time. I lived through a time of immense change and I honestly felt my way through it. There is no magic formula that helped me get to where I am, it was hard work, the right time and trusting your gut instinct.

Have you always known that you would be a person of influence?

Well I always I knew I wanted to do things that will have a positive influence on my community, family and career. If that lead me to be a person of influence then I'm honored.

Who are your role models personally and professionally as an African woman of global influence?

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My first role model is my mother. She defied all gender norms, when it was unfashionable to do so. She taught me from a young age to stand up for what I believe and fight for what I want.

The rose insignia of my brand is dedication to my childhood and her. My role model as an African woman is Winnie Madikizela Mandela.

She endured the most hardship during the struggle and persevered against all that was thrown at her. She is a symbol for all women who kept the struggle against apartheid alive, when their spouses were arrested.

What advice would you give to both young and more mature women who want to climb the corporate ladder and maintain a healthy family and life balance?

Firstly, there is no magic bullet that will give you balance, you have to find what works for you. From my own experience I had help from my parents and mother-in-law during my career.

I still had 5am wake up times to drop my kids off and it wasn't easy. Not everyone is this fortunate so you have to prioritize your life and make it work. You have to make sacrifices but always keep in mind that it is for the bigger picture. Which is the balance you seek.

What will be the biggest challenge for the generation of women behind you?

The biggest challenge will be to constantly keep up with the changing times. Everything is constantly and rapidly changing, therefore there is a need to constantly reinvent oneself. But honestly in the age of instant gratification, classic is always timeless. Be true to who you are, trends fade and change so be authentic.

What practices can we begin to put in place in order to move the global village closer towards gender equality?

It starts with education at grassroots level. Boys and girls should not be defined in stereotypical gender norms. If girls want to play football and boys want to do art then they should be encouraged.

The barriers of their parents should not entrap them. It creates a snowball effect where the world celebrates gender equality rather than constantly fighting for it.

Is there an unconscious bias of female leaders in the world of fashion?

All the biases come from a notion that you have had to come from a fashion school or a fashion family to cut it in this business. But the world has changed and if people still have biases then they are consciously choosing not to open their minds. I always think in the mind of a consumer because I am one. What I design is what I would buy.

Talk us through the inspiration behind your latest collection?

The inspiration behind 'The Question Collection' was to delve into our understanding of what knowledge is. You could say it is in the realm of meta-philosophy where the question is not the context but the actual notion of what our understanding of what knowledge is. I adapted this to art forms in three stories. The birth of knowledge, the classical form of knowledge and how we interpret it. The prints act like a story book which is complemented by crafted silhouettes.

What advice would you give to a budding designer wanting to make their mark in the fashion world?

I know it's contrived but always be yourself! Authenticity will get you a long way in this game. Also make an effort to understand the business side of fashion because it plays a major role in how you construct your label. A good balance of both is a winning combination.

In three words can you tell us what legacy you would like to leave for Africa?

Unity, Innovation and Love.



BRADLEY THEODORE MEETS WITH JOSEPH FARODOYE TO DISCUSS HIS PASSION FOR ART

How did you discover your passion?

I discovered it as a kid - as a kid I would always write on walls in my mother's house, I would get a beating for it (laughs) but I mean, I would write on everything and that's when I discovered it was my passion because it would always come out.

How did you become what we now know as Bradley Theodore?

It was simple, I spent about a year painting in my house and then I had a lot of my friends who were clients who would buy my work to sell - So they wanted to sell my work and I just wanted to paint and discover my visual language. One day one of my friends nagged me so much about selling my paintings, I decided to paint on the wall, that was when I painted the Anna Wintour and Karl Lagerfeld painting. This was my first wall painting and from that everything went like wildfire, people just loved it. There was a very famous blogger who posted it on their Instagram and it got about half a million hits, so people liked it, but he cut my name out. I was kind of mad about that,

because he was not being genuine and cutting the artist out. So, you're taking the image and receiving the praise for finding a cool image but you're not giving the person who created the image a chance to be received by the world. So, what I did was, I put my email address in the image so that anyone else who tried that couldn't take my name out and so for anyone who wanted to contact me directly, they would know where I work - That was a game changer!

What was your main catalyst to success?

That was it! When that wall was done it was featured in a double page spread in Grazia magazine and Marie Claire, people flew from Germany to take pictures in front of it...it just took off and this was all in the first two years. In the second year I didn't sell a painting to anyone, I made a conscious decision not to sell to anyone and to continue working on my creative journey.

How did you cultivate your creative journey?

I was painting while I was going back to the studio and experimenting, and one of my

goals was to paint whatever I liked or enjoyed, usually people paint what's hot at the time like musicians, rappers etc. and I kind of went against that. I was painting fashion icons which no one really wanted to paint, no one thought that was cool, but for me, it was a part of my life. Painting icons that helped shaped society and were either unknown or unappreciated.

How did you arrive at this point in your career?

I think most of the real reason I'm here is because I didn't initially succumb to the trickery that comes with the art world, I treated it like a business. I see this as a business, so instead of just focusing on being cool, I focused on the business side and tried to develop an organisation backend with this, making sure I keep key relationships in good standing.

What was your business model?

My business model was to be physically responsible, not to chase commissions. In the art world you get a lot of people taking commissions, not doing them and keeping the money. A lot of people lose a lot of money coming in and a lot of money going out buying champagne and gifts for people that didn't really deserve anything. There are a lot of 'hang-ons' and I didn't have a lot of 'hang-ons' – I still don't have a lot of 'hang-ons'. As a black artist, you get people assuming that you are not cognisant of structure and that you are not able to manage your business and financial affairs.

From the moment I met you, one thing that struck me about you was your confidence, how did you build your confidence as an artist?

Earlier on in my career when I started freelancing for record companies and working for creative agencies, there were big budgets behind my images. If you are working on a project and there is a \$5M budget and your image is going to lead this \$5M budget, you need to make sure that whatever you create is the best and can stand up to, next to and against the best and I was able to achieve that in those arenas. In those times I wasn't as confident, I didn't think that I was one of the best and I saw people take advantage of that. So, every year I made adjustments and I think this has adjusted me.

Tell me more about Bradley Theodore the person.

My mother raised me as an islander as we're from Turks and Caicos, we're a very small group of people, we don't nag too much we keep our heads high and we do our work. When we moved to this country (America) we moved to one of the roughest ghettos in history because of the project epidemic but my mother didn't know what was happening because she wasn't from there (laughs). But at the same time, we would walk to the beach with our fishing lines to catch fish. All the kids from the projects would ask us what we were doing, and we would tell them that we were going to catch fish. 'Well where are you going to catch fish from?' and we would respond 'from the seal' (laughs). So, we would come back with a bucket full of fish and the kids would ask 'where did you get all that free food from? And I would tell them again 'from the seal' (laughs). We had a different mentality from the other kids, being from Turks and Caicos where God gives you fruits, vegetables from the trees and plants and protein from the sea...simple.

So, you must have stood out?

We were basically targets, we were immigrants, initially there were immigrants from Jamaica, Haiti and the Bahamas. My father is half Haitian and Dominican, but we weren't considered any of that because we weren't Haitian and didn't speak French. No one knew where Turks and Caicos was, its small and there are less than 40k people on the island, so you would be hard pressed to find someone from Turks and Caicos. But my mother always kept us together and showed us the line between where we're from and what is being created. The environment that people associate themselves with as black culture is not true black culture it is made up black culture based on pure hardship. But I remember the sacrifice my mother made, I have 9 siblings, and am from a very respectable family in Turks and Caicos and that plays an important role in where I am today.

Meeting Bradley was truly an amazing experience and his level of dedication and the passion displayed for art and sharing his message with the world is uncommon. We look forward to working with Bradley in 2018....so watch this space!



A VISION FOR AFRICA

THE ESTATE MEETS KUNLE AWOSIKA HEAD OF SMALL, MEDIUM & CORPORATE (SMC) FOR WEST EAST AND CENTRAL AFRICA



Tell us about your journey to Head of Small, Medium and Corporate (SMC) for West East and Central Africa & Indian Ocean Islands?

The journey has been long spanning 17 years in the company with several roles in different regions within Africa. I started off with Microsoft in 2000 when they officially decided to invest in resources in Nigeria and I was fortunate to be one of the first three employees hired at the time. The events that led to my hiring was remarkable, as Nigeria had just established itself as a country with so much opportunity. Coming out of a military ruled government in 1999 into a civilian rule government and immediately thereafter it became attractive to many multinationals and corporations the world over. I took hold of the opportunity to engage a well-known global brand, Microsoft, as a young Executive and before long, I was required to move to Kenya due to its unique location in the African continent and the vibrancy/innovation of the Telco's in this part of the continent. In 2013, I received a call from the Microsoft Africa CEO to run the Kenya operations as the Country Head. This initially shocked me, however, it excited me because of the possibilities of driving growth in what we call the "Silicon Valley" of Africa (Kenya). I lead another arm of our business across Sub Saharan Africa working with a large team in several locations across the continent. I think this is the future of Africa – Helping small, medium and corporates to scale in this cloud and mobile first continent and the world. I am still on this journey and still excited!

Why was Microsoft Africa created?

Microsoft had identified Africa as a growing continent with over 60-70% of its population being youthful and GDP growth rates ranging from 5-9% especially during the oil boom periods. With growing urban population and developing cities scattered across Africa, Microsoft needed to support the continent with its unique offering of productivity tools, and cloud platforms that are helping businesses to grow and develop.

Beyond the attractiveness of the African market to Microsoft, I think prior to any tech company establishing here, Microsoft always had a moral obligation to develop markets, hence have invested heavily into our partner ecosystem, enabling young talents to gain certification in Microsoft technology and becoming employable in the job market.

Who is Microsoft Africa's target audience and why?

We target all businesses from large corporations to micro-small companies and consumers of technology at large. Our audience is global as we serve a wide segment of the market that have a need for our technology. I think the why question is always an interesting one. Our audience is described as having a hunger for the latest, most innovative and most affordable technology and we are constantly evaluating and re-evaluating how to serve them best. We have always taken a position of "empowering every person and organization on the planet to achieve more" as our mission.

How do you define success?

For me success is about positively contributing to the development of people, markets and communities. I see success as adding notable value to a scenario of hopelessness and turning it into a great story - I have lived this first hand within Africa, seeing individuals grow into professionalism, coaching individuals and teams to become better and to do more, helping businesses think about strategy and utilization of technology has excited me beyond measure.

What do you attribute to your success?

I never studied computer science in university or even while doing my MBA at Keele University (UK), as earlier mentioned I stumbled into working in a tech company based on a talent hunt when Microsoft established in Nigeria. I attribute my journey (not success) to Gods grace first of all and secondly to the power of positive thinking. I truly believe in conquering tasks brought before you with a growth mind-set as opposed to a fixed mind-set. There are significant opportunities that I was fortunate to have experienced over the years, one being meeting and archiving photos with our first CEO and founder Bill Gates. That was special!

If you could talk to one person from history, who would it be and why?

Mahatma Gandhi due to his role and contribution to India's Freedom Movement (one of the most populous countries in the world). His fight for National liberation through non-violent protest was a historical admiration to many and still is to this day. I admire such courage and the mental strength of one who has walked the corridors of this world leaving a note-worthy footprint. He had a cause and a purpose - Mahatma Gandhi spent most of his life fighting for political freedom for his people not political gain for his pocket. He was truly enigmatic and studying the evolution of India and its development reminds me in some part of the varying degrees of development in Africa.

Who has been your greatest inspiration?

My parents - growing up in a small family and reflecting on the many years of togetherness in our formative years, my parents stopped at nothing to provide everything required for my growth and development, it is enough to say - Thank you mum (rest in peace) and to my Dad - Keep moving. I wouldn't be here today if they had shelved their responsibilities as parents - I'm eternally grateful.

What would you say are the top three attributes needed for a tech company to be successful?

I don't think there are three or four things, however there are things I feel companies need, particularly in the tech space due to the speed of innovation and creativity unique to this industry.

Setting clear priorities: Ensuring that your teams have simple and clear priorities that define the true north for each individual, specifically towards the services/solution the company offers.

Implementing repeatable processes: Ensuring each individual team member is clear about how to gain efficiency by managing through common KPI's.

Constantly Innovating with relevance: Tech companies need to localize their services to meet the local needs of their consumers. So as HSBC say on their billboards, Think globally, act locally.

If you had one piece of advice to someone starting a business in the tech space for Africa, what would it be?

Start your company with the end in mind, but ensure you build with strong repeatable processes that will enable you to scale quickly. I would also say utilize the cloud technology available to you to kick-start and grow your business. Focus on treating your business as an expense (Opex) while driving for growth and profitability. Don't burn cash on hardware cost etc. cloud technology enables you to scale.

In three words can you sum up the legacy you would like to leave for Africa?

Capacity to Build, Transfer of Skills and Growth for my African brothers and sisters.

Bottom-line a flourishing Africa and we are here to do it.



SEVEN TOP TIPS FROM A **SELF-MADE** ENTREPRENEUR

FREDRICK Achom CEO of Rosemont Group catches up with Joseph Farodoye to reveal his top tips for business.

As an entrepreneur with a diverse range of businesses, I regularly get asked by people aspiring to run their own businesses what the key principles are that have helped me to achieve success. Frequently faced with this question, I try to give the best advice possible – but due to my busy schedule and not having a full understanding of the person's strengths, weaknesses and key qualities, it's hard to give that one piece of pivotal advice.

It's through dealing with this scenario that I have decided to write a list of the ten success principles that I have used to guide me in my business and personal life.

Hopefully you will find these tips useful and can implement some of these principles in your everyday life.

1. Choose a business that is scalable

One of the key criteria for me entering or investing in any business is the potential

scalability of that business. Many entrepreneurs go wrong by failing to research the market before going into it. It's common within the business world for business owners to limit their success by starting a business based on their passion, even if the market is not big enough for that business to grow.

So when considering a start-up business, it's essential that you choose a business that you will be passionate about, but what is also equally important is that you choose a business that is scalable.

The first step of checking the potential scalability of your business is to look at how big the market is and how great the current demand for your service or product is. Once you base your business on this foundation it makes your business life so much easier.

2. Make an effort to network regularly

Networking has been essential in helping me to grow my businesses and find great investment opportunities. Every successful partnership I've formed, every investment deal I've closed, started off by simply making the effort



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to network. Make a commitment to regularly attend events, seminars and exhibitions where you can meet new people who can potentially add value to your life. Through doing so, you will get the chance to share ideas with people and open new doors of opportunities for yourself.

3. Teamwork makes the dream work

When starting your business ensure that you equip yourself with the best possible team. When starting a business I have always focused on hiring talent that has strengths in the area of my weaknesses.

You must adopt this same attitude, even if at first you recruit just a single staff member to your team. Remind yourself that what can usually take one person months to do, as part of a team that person can accomplish the same thing in weeks. If you want to start reaping measurable results get the best team and delegate, delegate and delegate.

4. Be respectful

Treating others with respect has served me well and worked to my advantage in my personal

and business career. My parents raised me with the mind-set to treat all people equally and not differently because of the level of their achievement or the size of their net worth. I believe that every human has been blessed with a talent and has a lesson to offer. So my advice is to treat everyone with respect because you may one day need them. Do remember that someone down and out today could be the world's most important person in the future.

5. Cultivate your will power

I believe that the will to succeed is more powerful than the skill. I've met many people who have incredible natural talent and all the qualifications in the world, but due to their lack of motivation they don't get very far. I've also come across those who are less talented, but surpass the ones with natural gifts due to cultivating an undeniable will power and determination to succeed. My advice to you is not to limit your goals because of your lack of knowledge or skill; with the will power you will automatically attract the resources, skills and opportunities along the way.

6. Believe in yourself

The phrase "believe in yourself" is a cliché but very true. If you don't have any faith in yourself you will remain looking for external help, when actually you can help yourself. The moment you have self-belief and are confident you instantly become resourceful, productive and take more action than if you were less confident. The best advice I can give is to get into the habit of acting with self-confidence, acting like you have the answers, and then through time, confidence will become second nature to you.

7. Have a vision

Whenever I have decided to start a business I've always written down a vision to guide me in the right direction. It's important that in anything you do you set goals. It's by having a clear goal that you are able to figure out the most appropriate steps to get you there. When you write a vision for yourself make sure it's something compelling that you have a burning desire for. It's usually the big visions that will keep you working day and night to succeed.

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